

RIFLEMEN OF THE AMERICAN REVOLUTION

At the start of the American Revolutionary War in 1775, skilled riflemen were among the first companies of soldiers raised by the rebellious North American colonies to fight the British Army and its Loyalist supporters. These riflemen had their origins in the American frontier world of hunters and farmers, and relied on their skill with a long-barrelled rifle to carve out a life in the wild. Some riflemen were incorporated into units of General George Washington’s army, but others retained their independent spirit along with their own equipment and clothing. They proved themselves effective snipers and skirmishers.



◀ HATCHET

Date	c.1775
Origin	US
Weight	680g (24oz)
Length	35.5cm (14in)

A skilled hunter and woodsman, the rifleman usually carried a hatchet – tucked into his belt – for constructing shelters and making fires.

► GUN POUCH

Date	c.1775
Origin	US
Material	Leather

Riflemen carried a leather gun pouch slung over the shoulder. The pouch contained only the essentials for their rifle, while a linen haversack held personal items.



▲ FLINT POUCH

Date	c.1775
Origin	US
Material	Leather

Using tow (hemp or flax fibres) to catch sparks struck from his flint and steel, a rifleman could light a fire. He often also carried a pouch of dry kindling.



Butcher knife



Pan cover

▲ PENNSYLVANIA RIFLE

Date	1760
Origin	US
Weight	3.8kg (8¼lb)
Barrel	1.14m (3¾ft)
Calibre	.45

The flintlock weapon carried by the riflemen was an ancestor of the celebrated Kentucky rifle of later American frontiersmen. In well-trained hands, it had an accuracy of up to 365m (1,200ft). The long, rifled barrel made it far more accurate than the muskets used by European armies.

Undershirt



▲ HUNTING SHIRT

Date	c.1775
Origin	US
Material	Linen

Many riflemen favoured a fringed linen shirt worn with a belt fastened around the waist. The shirts were often dyed in natural shades of brown or green for camouflage.